# BASIC ELEMENTS OF RHETORIC

Nicoletta Di Blas – Introduction

# What is rhetoric?

- The "art of speaking"
- Ancient Greece, 5th century BC

"To a certain extent **all men attempt to discuss statements and to maintain them**, to defend themselves and to attack others. Ordinary people do this either at random or through practice and from acquired habit. Both ways being possible, the subject can plainly be handled systematically, for it is possible to inquire the reason why some speakers succeed through practice and others spontaneously; and every one will at once agree that such an inquiry is the function of an art"

(Aristotle, Rhetoric, 4th cent BC)

# The 5 parts of rhetoric:

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- «Inventio» (invention): finding arguments
- «Dispositio» (arrengement): putting arguments in order
- «Elocutio» (style): choosing the right style/wording
- «Memoria» (memory): *just for public speaking* – learning the talk by heart
- «Actio» (delivery): *just for public speaking* – non verbal aids (how to move, how to change tone of voice…)

# Part1: inventio

- Inventio=latin IN-VENIRE to «bump into»
- Invention: finding arguments, finding «what to say»

There is no algorithm: we cannot be sure to have found all the arguments in favor/against of a thesis, even less that we have found the best arguments. We can only try… and we do not even know how much time it will take! It may take hours as well as minutes; good ideas can occur when least expected.
ETHOS: Credibility – Why should we listen to this author?
PATHOS: In what way will the addressee be affected (positively-negatively)? Why should the addressee CARE? MAKE THE ADDRESSEE CONNECTED TO THE ISSUE

# Examples from commercials

SENDER: I've been making tortellinis for more than 50 years; My company is steadily growing
ADDRESSEE: the ad suggests that this is how you become if you user this perfume
LOGOS: these are the positive characteristics of the product (slow squeezing tech)

# Arguments/1

- Arguments can be related to:
  - The author/sender (ETHOS)
  - The addressee (PATHOS)
  - The thing under discussion (LOGOS)
    - reason, facts and figures

# Arguments/2

- Arguments can anticipate what the addressee wants/thinks
  - It is useful to think about:
    - (2-3) possible **objections** and be ready to answer
    - (2-3) possible **wishes** and be ready to fulfill them

"This campus is extremely locked down due to security, but as part of this tour, <u>you will get to explore the areas that only employees are typically allowed to venture</u>."

(from the description of a Silicon valley tour)

# Implicit vs. explicit

- A “base-line” in communication: you always have to choose
  - Explicit: to be sure!
    - Example (again from commercials)
  - Implicit: often, more effective
    - Example (a CV, before and after)
    - People like to draw their own conclusions
      - Careful: this may be deceitful

# Key-messages and key-values/1

- Key messages: what you want your addressee to remember
- Key values: what you want your addressee to feel

# Key-messages and key-values/2

- Example: University of Italian Switzerland

MESSAGES

VALUES

## Why USI

Seven reasons for choosing USI:

- Quality of the Swiss university system
- International faculty
- Leading interdisciplinary education
- Teacher/student ratio 1 to 8
- Strong ties with the business world
- Flexible structure, open to the exchange of ideas
- International, dynamic and welcoming environment

# Part 2: dispositio

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- Arrangement: how to organize the arguments
- It depends on the “context”:
  - Written vs. oral communication
  - Span of attention by the audience
  - Interruptions?
  - Kind of presentation
  - …

# The “Nestorian” order

- STRONG
- LESS STRONG
- STRONG

In what cases:
- Written text, conference, lesson, …

Pre-conditions:
- Continuous attention by the audience

# Descending climax

- STRONG
- LESS STRONG
- LESS STRONG
- …

In what cases:
- TV footage, interview…

Pre-condition: short span of attention

# Ascending climax

- LESS STRONG
- SCALING UP
- STRONG

In what cases:
- High expectations

Pre-condition:
- continuous attention, captive public

Steve Jobs Introducing The iPhone At MacWorld 2007

# Winning of favor

- Possible start
- “Captatio benevolentiae”: winning of favor
- 3 (main) ways

## 1) Praise the audience

"I'm honored to be introduced by someone who writes so powerfully about the past and is working so effectively to shape the future. […] I'm honored to be here with all of you and to be here at Freedom House. For more than 50 years, Freedom House has been a voice for tolerance for human dignity. People all over the world are better off because of your work.»

(Bill Clinton, at the Freedom House in 1995)

## 2) Show understanding

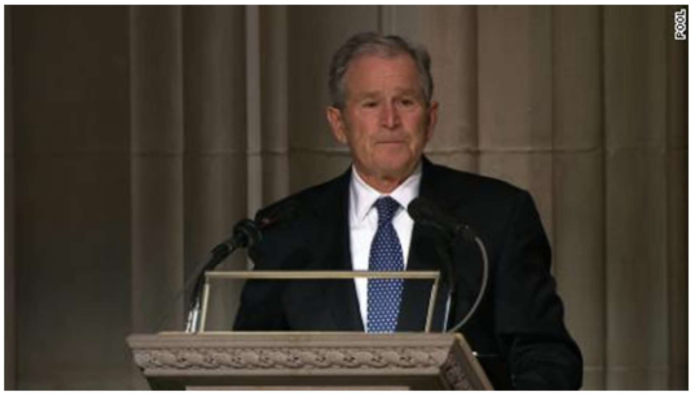
"I have roots in the countryside, as I also harvested potatoes, […] I spent the cold winter evenings in the stables where it was warm and wonderful country stories were told. I spent many years of my childhood in the Como countryside. These are values that cannot be forgotten, that one carries throughout one's life."

(Silvio Berlusconi, «Confagricoltura» meeting, an Italian association of , 27 Sept. 27, 1994)

## 3) Be humble and/or self-ironic

"I want to thank you for overlooking my dress code violation. They were about to stop me at the door, but Irving Kristol said, "I know this guy, let him in."

(George Bush, annual dinner of the American Enterprise Institute, Feb. 26 2003)



# Part 3: elocutio

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- Elocutio
  - «Dress» ideas in words
  - Style does make a difference!
  - Figures of speech
    - Of «thoughts» and «words»
    - E.g. metaphore: a figure of thought: «Louis is a lion»

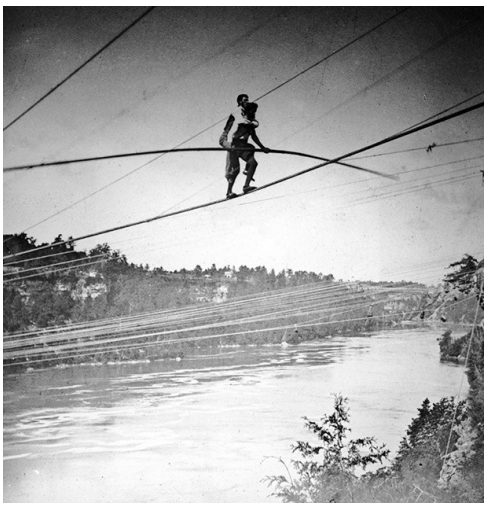
Example of figure of words: alliteration, i.e. a series of words which frequently use the same letter, usually at the beginning of successive words. *saeva sedens super arma* (Vergil, *Aeneid* 1. 294).
Figures of thought can be translated into other languages while figures of words cannot be translated: they depend on the specific language.

# Example 1

- American civil war (1861 to 1865)
- Abraham Lincoln addresses those who urged a change of commanders in the middle of the Civil War
- He is AGAINST a change of commanders

# Example 1 – the speech

«Gentlemen, I want you to **suppose a case for a moment.** Suppose that all the property you were worth was in gold, and you had to put it in the hands of Blondin, the famous ropewalker, to carry across the Niagara falls on a tight rope. Would you shake the rope while he was passing over it, or keep shouting to him , 'Blondin, stoop a little more! Go a little faster!' No, I'm sure you would not. You would hold your breath as well as your tongue, and keep your hands off until he was safely over. **Now, the government is in the same situation.** It is carrying an immense weight across a stormy ocean. Untold treasures are in its hands. It is doing the best it can. Don't badger it! Just keep still, and it will get you safely over.»



Lincoln uses two powerful similitudes:

1) the government as a ropewalker
2) The government as a ship over stormy waters

"We shall not flag or fail. We shall go on to the end. We shall fight in France, **we shall fight** on the seas and oceans, **we shall fight** with growing confidence and growing strength in the air, we shall defend our island, whatever the cost may be, **we shall fight** on the beaches, **we shall fight** on the landing grounds, we shall fight in the fields and in the streets, we shall fight in the hills; we shall never surrender."

(Winston Churchill, 1864)

Example 2.1 – figure of words: **anaphora**

## Example 2.2 – figure of words: anaphora

I have to confess that when we started our Food Security Initiative, I did not know that most food was grown by women. I remember once driving through Africa with a group of distinguished experts. And I saw women working in the fields and I saw women working in the markets and I saw women with wood on their heads and water on their heads and children on their backs. And I remarked that women just seem to be working all the time. And one of the economists said, 'But it doesn't count.' I said, 'How can you say that?' He said, 'Well, it's not part of the formal economy.' I said, 'Well, if every woman who did all that work stopped tomorrow, the formal economy would collapse'

(H. Clinton, ***Address to the United Nations Commission on the Status of Women*** delivered 12 March 2010, United Nations, New York).

# Example 3/1

Draft ideas to convey (for a project proposal):

- We are talking about cultural heritage institutions
- For CH institution, “going digital” is inevitable
- Poor institutions: they can’t afford it
- … there is a digital divide!

GOAL:

- To convey how striking the gap between rich and poor institution is
- Rich institutions even if poor from the point of view of content seem more important than poor institutions that would be instead rich from the point of view of content

# Example 3/2

- Countries like Italy for example, with “distributed” cultural heritage consisting of an incredible number of minute cultural “episodes” (little villages, tiny churches, small archaeological sites...) encounter a clear disadvantage: such scattered information is difficult to collect within a consistent global picture, especially with limited individual resources. Even larger “episodes”, such as the “Galleria degli Uffizi” (in Florence, Italy) may be not adequately “visible”. The readers are encouraged to see for themselves the information provided over the Internet about these museums and how “culturally appealing” it is, compared with equivalent information provided by any average museum in the USA.

In the slides, an excerpt from the project proposal is presented. The text has to convey the ideas previously identified in the brainstorming phase of invention (previous slide). The final sentence suggests a similitude: small institutions are turned into “dwarves” (even if they are not so in terms on intrinsic value of their exhibits) by bigger institutions that can afford a better tech-based communication (and thus look as “giants”)

# Example 3/2

- …The divide is striking: <u>over the Internet, giants of the cultural world may be dwarfed by institutions of medium relevance.</u>

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# Step 4: memoria

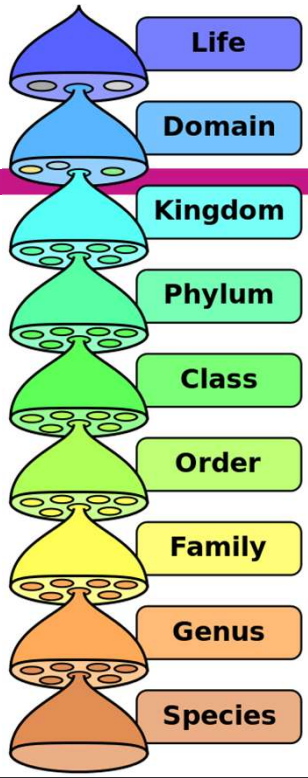
- Memory
  - Keep in mind the arguments and their order
  - Use «aides memoires»
    - E.g. associate the main arguments to something you know well
    - Create a “scene”

When rhetoric was invented (ancient Greece) keeping things in mind was a necessity; nowadays we have a lot of supports: papers, slides…
Still, it is useful to remember at least the main arguments we mean to convey and their order.

# Loci ciceroniani

- Imagine you are living another life, in a faraway domain where the king is called Philipp.
- He wants to teach you a class and orders a family to step forward.
- He says "I know there is a genius among you, and I want to know who he is. And please be specific, since I want to reward him."

(Boris Nikolai Konrad – TED talk)




Example: taxonomic ranks in biology

# Step 5: actio

- Voice
- Gestures
- Movements

TIPS:

- Rehearse! At least 4 times
- Prepare the first sentence you are going to say
- Use eye-contact, with single individuals

Example of exercise to enhance fluency: speak words – randomly chosen – aloud for a minute, without using any kind of “saying” or sounds like “mmm”.

# Things to pay attention to:

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- Audience: free or captive?
- Tools
- Unforseen events
- Expectations
- Space
- TIME

The different kinds of audience imply different «invention» processes; if I talk to people who share my political views, for example, I do not need to persuade them, I need to reinforce their opinion.
Captive audience: people «cannot» go away (like for example students in a class…). This has consequences on invention and arrangement: the speaker does not have to worry about people suddendly going away because they are bored or annoyed.
Tools: e.g. videos, slides… Use them but do not depend on them.
Unforseen events (e.g. someone entering the room): do not fight them, use them as «allies». If everyone gets distracted, they won't be listening anyway.
TIME: make the best possible use of the time you are given, even if very short; never try to squeeze too much content in too little space. Never say «due to lack of time, unfortunately…» giving the idea you were not able to use your time well.
And remember: Nothing is too long if you know how long it lasts (Quintilian). Always make it clear how much time your speech lasts.

# Note on slides

Relevant dimensions to consider:

- Context (lecture vs. online course)
- Aim (support for the speaker or for the learner?)
- Speaker's confidence

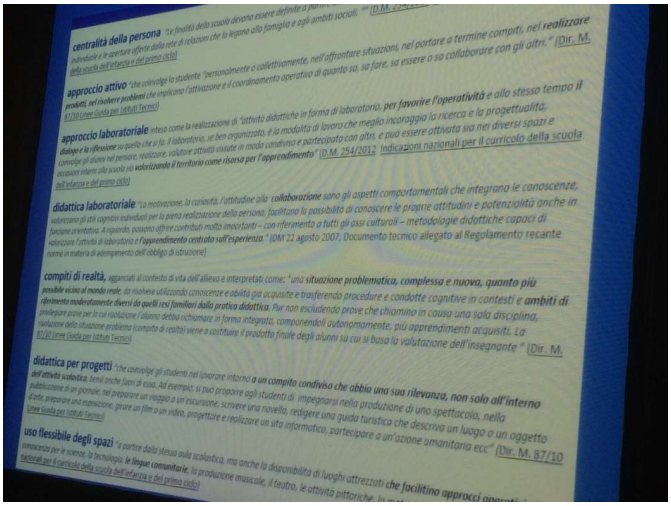
2 extremes:

- Slides with full text
- Slides with bullet lists

REMEMBER: slides are both a help and a competitor

Slides can take very different styles, according to (1) the context where they will be used (e.g. if they are meant to be used for an online course, they must be «self-standing» i.e. explain everything); (2) aim (are they meant to just remind the speaker of her main arguments?); (3) speaker's confidence (is the speaker shy? Then she will need a lot of texts on the slide).

# Example 1–too much content



**centralità della persona** "Le finalità della scuola devono essere definite a partire dai bisogni formativi degli alunni, dalle loro esigenze individuali e le aperture offerte dalla rete di relazioni che la legano alla famiglia e agli ambiti sociali." (D.M. 254/2012 Indicazioni nazionali per il curricolo della scuola dell'infanzia e del primo ciclo)

**approccio attivo** "che coinvolge lo studente "personalmente e collettivamente, nell'affrontare situazioni, nel portare a termine compiti, nel **realizzare prodotti, nel risolvere problemi** che implicano l'attivazione e il coordinamento operativo di quanto so, sa fare, sa essere o sa collaborare con gli altri." (Dir. M. 87/10 Linee Guida per Istituti Tecnici)

**approccio laboratoriale** inteso come la realizzazione di "attività didattiche in forma di laboratorio, **per favorire l'operatività** e allo stesso tempo il **dialogo e la riflessione** su quello che si fa. Il laboratorio, se ben organizzato, è la modalità di lavoro che meglio incoraggia la ricerca e la progettualità, coinvolge gli alunni nel pensare, realizzare, valutare attività vissute in modo condiviso e partecipato con altri, e può essere attivata sia nei diversi spazi e accessori interni alla scuola sia **valorizzando il territorio come risorsa per l'apprendimento**" (D.M. 254/2012 Indicazioni nazionali per il curricolo della scuola dell'infanzia e del primo ciclo)

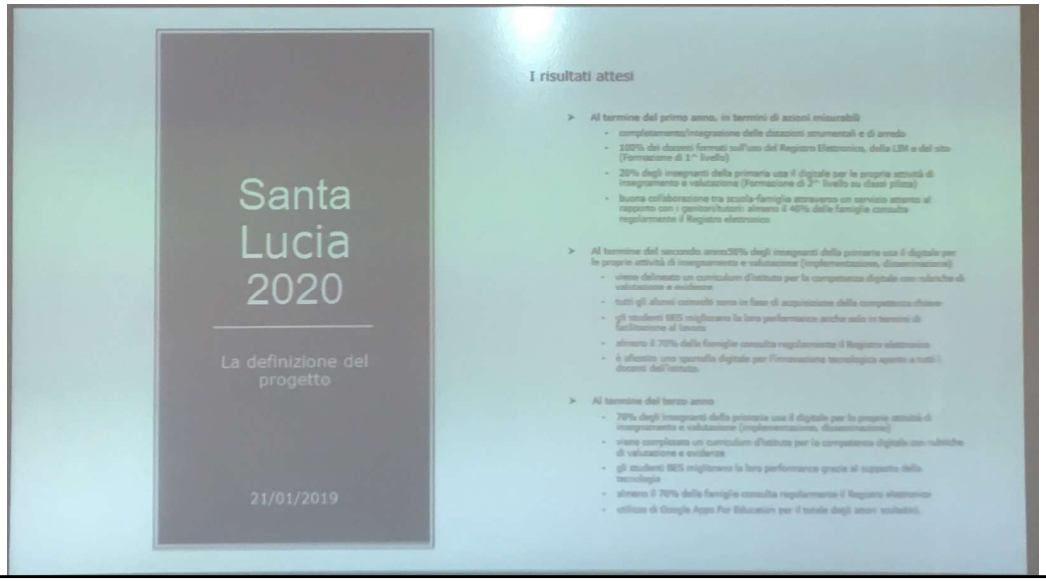
**didattica laboratoriale** "La motivazione, la curiosità, l'attitudine alla **collaborazione** sono gli aspetti comportamentali che integrano le conoscenze, valorizzano gli stili cognitivi individuali per la piena realizzazione della persona, facilitano la possibilità di conoscere le proprie attitudini e potenzialità anche in funzione orientativa. A riguardo, possono offrire contributi molto importanti – con riferimento a tutti gli assi culturali – metodologie didattiche capaci di valorizzare l'attività di laboratorio e **l'apprendimento centrato sull'esperienza**." (DM 22 agosto 2007, Documento tecnico allegato al Regolamento recante norme in materia di adempimento dell'obbligo di istruzione)

**compiti di realtà,** agganciati al contesto di vita dell'allievo e interpretati come: "una **situazione problematica, complessa e nuova, quanto più possibile vicina al mondo reale**, da risolvere utilizzando conoscenze e abilità già acquisite e trasferendo procedure e condotte cognitive in contesti e **ambiti di riferimento moderatamente diversi da quelli resi familiari dalla pratica didattica**. Pur non escludendo prove che chiamino in causa una sola disciplina, privilegiare prove per le cui risoluzione l'alunno debba richiamare in forma integrata, componendoli autonomamente, più apprendimenti acquisiti. La realizzazione della situazione-problema (compito di realtà) viene a costituire il prodotto finale degli alunni su cui si basa la valutazione dell'insegnante." (Dir. M. 87/10 Linee Guida per Istituti Tecnici)

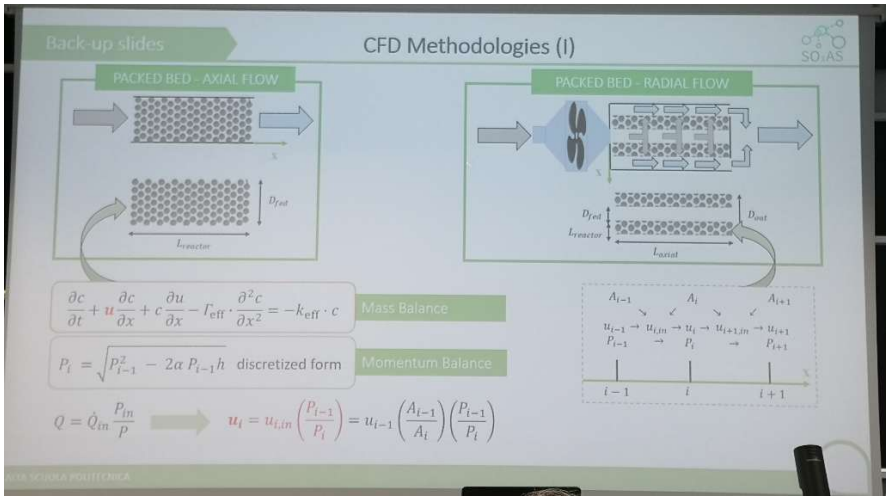
**didattica per progetti** "che coinvolge gli studenti nel lavorare intorno **a un compito condiviso che abbia una sua rilevanza, non solo all'interno dell'attività scolastica**: tenti anche fuori di essa. Ad esempio, si può proporre agli studenti di: impegnarsi nella produzione di uno spettacolo, nella pubblicazione di un giornale, nel preparare un viaggio o un'escursione, scrivere una novella, redigere una guida turistica che descriva un luogo o un oggetto d'arte, preparare una esposizione, girare un film o un video, progettare e realizzare un sito informatico, partecipare a un'azione umanitaria ecc." (Dir. M. 87/10 Linee Guida per Istituti Tecnici)

**uso flessibile degli spazi** "a partire dalla stessa aula scolastica, ma anche la disponibilità di luoghi attrezzati **che facilitino approcci** conoscenza per le scienze, la tecnologia, **le lingue comunitarie**, la produzione musicale, il teatro, le attività pittoriche, in [illegible] nazionali per il curricolo della scuola dell'infanzia e del primo ciclo)

# Example 2 – unreadable slide



# Example 3 – technical slide




If you have time, you can linger on the slide and explain all the details: the audience has to be able to grasp the meaning (common ground). If there is not enough time, a quite "technical" (with graphs, schema, calculations…) slide simply says "there actually is a technical ground to what I'm saying (and of course I cannot get into details).

# Technical slides – tip

- It is useful to add a small sentence summarizing the "sense" of a technical slide: what all those figures/graphs etc. "say"
  - E.G. "The experimentation provided better outcomes than the traditional method"
- Have additional slides ready
  - For technical questions
  - For possible objections…

# END